

LOW-COST FLYING



Bagdogra WEST BENGAL

Travelling light

Cut-rate flights have expanded businesses, changed lives and brought the never-haves closer to the always privileged

■ By Swagata Sen

As first-time air-travellers, the Kumars aren't aware that they have an entire air-conditioned airport lounge at their disposal. Forty-something Sandhya Devi and Kanta Devi squat on the pavement in front of the domestic terminal. Kumari Meena, 19, an engineering student and the smartest of the lot, says they

have just taken a train from Bokaro this morning, for their flight to Port Blair from Kolkata. This is the new flier, with the low-cost airline having changed his lifestyle completely. Not so long ago, the rich flew and the not-so-rich took trains. Now, the not-so-rich book flights for as little as Rs 700, the same price as a sleeper class ticket, and take off to their destinations.

Choices are increasing by the day. In addition to Air Deccan, Indigo, Spicejet and the new Jetlite, there are regional airlines such as Paramount in the South. Did you know, you could actually fly to places such as Jamnagar, Kolhapur, Jabalpur, Pathankot, Jamshedpur and even Kandla, if you have heard of

them? As one takes an Air Deccan flight to Bagdogra, one wonders, on seeing the tarmac from above, where the plane would really land. At one time, the city had two flights a day, one which had five stops between Delhi and Imphal (and took as long as an overseas flight), and the holidayer's best bet of reaching Darjeeling and Gangtok was the Darjeeling Mail, where your name would be perennially wait-listed. Now, there are six direct flights to the airport everyday, from Kolkata, Guwahati and Delhi, and the airport witnesses a scramble for parking space, meant for four aircraft. "We have a new domestic airport coming up nearby, while this one is going to be turned into an international terminal to cater to flights from Bhutan, Nepal and Bangladesh," says Gour Ghosh, an Airports Authority of India official.

Such is the awe of air travel that the passengers don't mind scrambling for seats (as there are no seat numbers) or overlook that the seats don't recline. V.P. Singh, a GAIL employee, who can't handle long journeys, has cancelled his Rajdhani ticket for a

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PER CENT IS THE OCCUPANCY RATIO IN LOW-COST AIRLINES WHILE THIS IS 70 PER CENT IN OTHER AIRLINES. ON AN AVERAGE, THESE AIR FARES ARE CHEAPER BY 60 PER CENT.

low-cost flight, for just a few rupees more. Psychiatrist Siladitya Ray, whose chamber is in Siliguri, has made it a weekly ritual to fly to Bagdogra and back to Kolkata on weekends. Soon, in the manner of an exaggerated advertisement, people might be flying down for a haircut. If they aren't already.



FLYING FAR AND LOW: Passengers at Bagdogra airport